

Process Analysis Paragraphs

Unit 7

GOAL: To learn how to write a process analysis paragraph

*** Language Focus:** Transition words and chronological order

What did you do to get ready for class today? Think about what you did first, then second, and so on. Perhaps you woke up and took a shower. After that, maybe you got dressed and combed your hair. As you prepared yourself to come to class, you completed a process.

The world is full of processes. At times, you are required to describe how to do something or how something works. You can often use a **process analysis paragraph** to convey the information.

What Is a Process Analysis Paragraph?

In a process analysis paragraph, you divide a process into separate steps. Then you list or explain the steps in chronological order—the order of events as they happen over time. Special time words or phrases allow you to tell the reader when a particular step occurs. The process analysis paragraph ends with a specific result—something that happens at the end of the process.

A process analysis paragraph

- explains a sequence or process.
- presents facts and details in chronological order.
- uses time words or phrases.
- ends with a specified result.

The best way to learn what a process analysis paragraph looks like is to read and study several examples. Even though the three paragraphs that follow are about different topics, each one is an example of a process analysis paragraph.

ANALYZING THE MODEL

The writing model explains a process that students can follow so that their teachers will be more likely to give them good grades.

Read the model. Then answer the questions.



Writing Model

Impress for Success

1 When it is time to be evaluated by your professors, you want them to remember you—and remember you in a positive way. 2 As an experienced student, I know that it is easier to make a good impression on your course instructors if you follow these fundamental steps. 3 First, before you go to class, do all of the assigned reading and homework. 4 Good preparation will help you to follow the professor's lecture more easily, ask intelligent questions, and keep up with the class. 5 Second, arrive for class a few minutes early. 6 That way, you can get a good seat and have enough time to get organized. 7 You want to be ready so that you will not disturb the professor or your classmates while the class is going on. 8 For the same reason, you should also turn off your cell phone as you are getting ready. 9 Next, participate actively throughout the lesson. 10 Smile, nod, and make eye contact with your instructor. 11 Take notes. 12 If the professor asks a question, it is not necessary for you to jump at the chance to answer. 13 However, if no one else speaks up, show what you know. 14 If there is something that you do not understand, wait for an appropriate time to ask about it. 15 Finally, when the class meeting ends, remain seated. 16 Take a few minutes to collect your belongings and make last-minute additions to your notes. 17 If you still have questions, talk to your professor in the classroom. 18 Alternatively, you can send an email or clear up your confusion during the professor's office hours. 19 If you follow these steps in all of your courses, you will be better prepared for your tests, and your teachers will be ready to give you the good grades that you deserve.

Questions about the Model

1. Underline the topic sentence. What words let you know that the paragraph will explain a process?
2. According to this paragraph, what are the fundamental steps in the process of doing well in class?
3. What kind of information does the last sentence of the paragraph contain? Why did the writer include this sentence?

TOPIC SENTENCES IN PROCESS PARAGRAPHS

In a process paragraph, the topic sentence names the topic and tells the reader to look for a process or procedure. Use words such as *steps*, *procedure*, *process*, *directions*, *suggestions*, and *instructions*.

It will be easy for you to make a good impression on your course instructors if you follow these fundamental **steps**.

Use this step-by-step **process** to increase your reading speed.

These simple **instructions** clearly show how to make the battery on a laptop computer last longer.

Exercise 1: Write a set-up sentence and a topic sentence for the following process paragraphs

Eating a Messy Food

[redacted] First, you must be sure that you are wearing clothes that you do not mind getting dirty. Eating a taco while you are wearing an expensive silk blouse is not a smart idea. The next thing that you should do is to decide if you want to eat the taco alone or in front of others. Eating a taco in front of someone you do not know very well can be **embarrassing**. It is important to plan your attack! It is a good idea to pick up the taco gently and then carefully keep it in a **horizontal** position. As you raise the taco, slowly turn your head toward it and position your head at a twenty-degree **angle**. The last step is to put the corner of the taco in your mouth and take a bite. By following these simple directions, eating a taco can be a less messy experience.



EXAMPLE PARAGRAPH 50

Applying to an American University

[redacted] The first step is to choose several schools that you are interested in attending. Next, write to these schools to ask for information, **catalogs**, and applications. You may also want to visit the schools' **Web sites**. After you have **researched** several schools, **narrow** your list to between three and five schools. Then mail all the required forms and documents only to your final list of three to five schools. If the school of your choice requires you to take a standardized test, such as the SAT™, ACT, or TOEFL®, be sure to do so early. In addition, ask various school officials and teachers to write letters of recommendation for you if the university requires them. Finally, almost all schools have an application **fee**. This fee should be sent in the form of a check or money order. One last piece of advice is to start early because thousands of high school students are all applying at the same time.

SUPPORTING SENTENCES IN PROCESS PARAGRAPHS

The supporting sentences in a process paragraph are the steps and details about each step in the process.

First, before you go to class, do assigned reading and any other homework. Good preparation will enable you to understand the professor's lecture more easily, ask intelligent questions, and keep up with the class.

If you want to read faster and with more fluency, the second step is to put your dictionary in a hard-to-reach place so that you will use it less often.

Next, go to the control panel of the computer and look for the power saving functions.

Exercise 2: Sequencing the following steps to make a coherent process paragraph

The following sentences make up a paragraph. Number them from 1 to 8 to indicate the best order. Then underline all the words or phrases that show time order or sequence.

- _____ a. Hit the ball into the small box on the opposite side of the net.
- _____ b. After you hit the ball, continue swinging your racket down and across the front of your body.
- _____ c. Just before the ball reaches its peak, begin to swing your racket forward as high as you can reach.
- _____ d. First, toss the ball with your left hand about three feet in the air. The best position for the ball is just to the right of your head.
- _____ e. At the same time, move your racket behind your shoulder with your right hand so that your elbow is pointed toward the sky.
- _____ f. After you have completed the serve, your racket should be near your left knee.
- _____ g. Many people think serving in tennis is difficult, but the following steps show that it is quite easy.
- _____ h. If you are left-handed, you should substitute the words *left* and *right* in the preceding directions.

USING TIME ORDER IN PROCESS PARAGRAPHS

In a process paragraph, you arrange the steps in a process in order by time, and you use time-order signals to guide your reader from step to step. You are already familiar with time-order signals from Chapter 2. Here are some useful signals for process paragraphs.

TIME-ORDER SIGNALS	EXAMPLES
Sentence Connectors	
First, (Second, etc.)	First , preheat the oven to 500 degrees Fahrenheit.
Then (no comma)	Then prepare the pizza sauce.
Now (no comma)	
Next,	
Finally,	
After that,	
Meanwhile,	
Others	
The first step . . . (no comma)	The next step is to mix the pizza dough.
The next step . . . (no comma)	After five minutes , check the pizza.
The final step . . . (no comma)	After you take the pizza out of the oven , cut it into eight pieces.
After five minutes,	
After you take the pizza out of the oven,	

Complete the paragraph. Use the time-order and conclusion signals from the box. Capitalize and punctuate them as needed. Use each signal once.

Exercise 3:

finally ~~the first step~~ second to sum up the third step

Choosing Classes

Choosing the right classes each semester can be stressful, but you can reduce your stress with a commonsense process. The first step
1.
is to become familiar with the graduation requirements for your major. It is a good idea to meet with an academic advisor, but do not depend entirely on others to give you correct information. Instead, use your school's website to find out what the requirements for your degree are, and memorize them.

2. plan, plan, plan. Write out a program for each semester when you talk to your advisor so that you can be certain you have all the courses you need for graduation. Be aware that some classes have prerequisites—classes you must pass before you can register for them.

3. is to talk with as many older students as you can. Ask them which courses are good and which ones are not. Do not waste your time or money on bad classes. 4. register each semester as soon as you can. Waiting even an hour may mean that the classes you want or need are filled. 5. plan ahead to avoid missing any required classes, to steer clear of bad classes, and to graduate on time.

SUBORDINATORS	EXAMPLES
Time Subordinators	
after	He goes to school after he finishes work.
as*	I entered the classroom as the professor was beginning her lecture.
as soon as	The professor stopped talking as soon as I entered the room.
before	Before you attend college, you have to fill out an application.
since*	It has been an hour since the test started.
until	We can't leave the room until everyone has finished the test.
when	When you start college, you sometimes have to take a placement test.
whenever	Whenever I don't sleep well, I feel sick the next day.
while	I felt nervous while I was taking my first exam.

Exercise 4:

Work with a partner. Read the first draft of "Note Taking 101" on page 116. Mark up and revise the paragraph so that it flows better and contains more sentence variety. Follow the instructions:

1. Use compound and complex sentences to improve the paragraph.
2. Combine sentences to connect ideas logically.
3. Use transition signals to connect the supporting sentences.
4. Use time, reason, purpose, and condition subordinators.
5. Add punctuation where needed.

Note Taking 101

You are listening to a professor's lecture. Are you having trouble taking notes? There is no need to feel frustrated. A good note-taking process is actually quite easy. Bring a notebook. Bring something to write with. You will have the basic tools you need. Make good decisions about what to include in your notes. You should write what a professor puts on the board. Write what a professor shows on a projection screen. It is usually important information. You will notice that the professor uses signal words and phrases. You hear "the most important reason" or a similar phrase. Pay attention. Add that information to your lecture notes. You will need to develop a system of symbols and abbreviations to increase your note-taking speed. You can use "w/o" to mean "without" or "+" and "-". You want to indicate positive ideas. You want to indicate negative ideas. You go to your next class. Be sure to review your notes. Ask your teacher any questions that you have. With this note-taking system, you will feel more confident in class and be better prepared for your next exam.

CONCLUDING SENTENCES IN PROCESS PARAGRAPHS

In a process paragraph, the concluding sentence can explain the last step, or it can sum up the results of following the entire process.

If you follow these steps in all of your courses, you will be better prepared for your tests, and your teachers will be ready to give you the good grades that you deserve.

You will soon find that you can not only read faster but also understand much more.

Finally, turn the laptop off when you are not using it.

Exercise 6: Write the concluding sentence for each of the following paragraphs

How to Email Your Course Instructor

1 It is common for students to contact their professors by email to ask a question, explain an absence, or submit an assignment. 2 Before you click the send button on your next email to an instructor, remember that such an email is a piece of business writing with very specific requirements. 3 First of all, use your school email account. 4 Because the address for this account probably has at least part of your name and the name of your school, it is less likely to go to junk mail. 5 In addition, your professor will recognize the address when he sees it and know that your message is important. 6 Second, clearly state your purpose in the subject line of the email. 7 For example, you can say, "Paul Lee's Final Draft—Essay #3 English 100-02." 8 After that, move on to your actual message. 9 Start out with a greeting such as "Hi, Professor Smith" or the more formal, "Dear Professor Smith." 10 In the body of your email, once again be very clear and direct. 11 For instance, if you are going to be absent from class, give a brief explanation. 12 Never write an email more than one screen in length. 13 Email messages should be short enough to be read and understood quickly. 14 Also avoid using slang and text messaging abbreviations such as "ru" and "btw." 15 End your message with a simple "Thank You" or "Best Regards." 16 Then add your full name and the name and number of your course. 17 Finally, check your email carefully for grammar and spelling mistakes before you send it off. 18 Such details are important as this is not a Facebook post or an informal text message to a friend. 19 Your email must be somewhat formal since you and your professor are involved in the business of teaching and learning.



What to Do If the Emergency Alarm Sounds During Class

When you hear the school's emergency alarm, follow the required safety procedures. It is possible that there is an actual emergency or that the alarm is signaling a practice evacuation. In either case, you and your classmates must exit the building. First, take all of your personal belongings with you. Quickly put everything into your bag or backpack. Second, find the nearest stairway and go down the stairs to the first floor lobby. Do not use the elevators. Even if it is your first emergency situation, stay calm. Walk. Don't run. After you leave the building, follow the instructions of the safety leaders who are outside. Finally, you can reenter the building as soon as the police and fire department have announced that, in fact, there is no danger.

WRITING ASSIGNMENT

*Write a paragraph of 150-200 words in length by using the given ideas in the outline to describe **the process of writing a good paragraph.***

Topic Sentence: _____

A. Main Point: _____

1. Supporting Detail: _____

B. Main Point: _____

1. Supporting Detail: _____

C. Main Point: _____

1. Supporting Detail: _____

Concluding Sentence: _____